

Duplexing: This refers to the ability of a printer to print on both sides of a paper. It is a very handy way of saving paper. However, this option is neither cheap, nor common. An alternative is to use manual duplexing. In this method, you print the odd, or even-numbered pages first, and once the job is completed, you manually flip the pages over and the printer prints on the other side.

Epson emulation: The industry standard control codes for dot matrix printers were developed by Epson and virtually all software packages and most dot matrix printers either follow or improve on these codes.

Halftone: An illustration reproduced by breaking down the original tone into a pattern of dots of varying size. Light areas have small dots and darker areas or shadows have larger dots.

Ink jet printer: Unlike daisy wheel and dot matrix printers, which rely on physical contact with the an inked ribbon and paper, ink jet printers simply spray ink in a series of dots to form characters. While early ink jets were prone to clogging, they were capable of delivering good print speeds and relatively high-quality text and graphics. Today's best ink jet printers have eliminated most of the clogging problems, rival laser printers for text quality, and can also produce color images with near-photographic quality—all for even less money than a low-end laser printer.

Interface: This is the type of connection that the printer has with the computer. Older printers use the parallel interface, but this has become obsolete. The latest printers use either USB or FireWire connections as their interface.

International paper sizes: The International Standards Organization (ISO) system of paper sizes is based on a series of three sizes A, B and C. Series A is used for general printing and stationery, Series B for posters and Series C for envelopes.

LASER: An acronym for Light Amplification by Stimulated Emission of Radiation, it is a process that produces a very intense light beam. In a laser printer, this beam is used to fuse the toner, or ink, onto the paper.

Layout: A sketch of a page for printing showing the position of text and illustrations, and giving general instructions.

Overprinting: Printing over an area already printed. Used to emphasize changes or alterations.

Pantone: A registered trademark for an ink colour matching system.

Printer Command Language: A language developed by HP for use with its own range of printers. Essentially a text orientated language, it has been expanded to give graphics capability.

PostScript: This is a computer language, or protocol used for communication between the computer and the printer. The computer sends information about the pages to be printed by the printer in PostScript format.

Print engine: The parts of a page printer which perform the print-imaging, fixing and paper transport. In fact, everything but the controller.

Progressives: Colour proofs taken at each stage of printing showing each colour printed singly, and then superimposed on the preceding colour.

The Future of Printers

The advocates of paperless environments had predicted the death of the printer. Concepts such as e-mail, e-paper, e-books and digital collaboration have certainly taken us closer to a paperless work culture. However, the printer is here to stay. The dot-matrix printer, once the norm, is dead—it's limited to billing and accounting applications. The future lies in laser printers. Currently though, inkjet printers rule when it comes to photo-quality printing.

The past few months have seen the emergence of a new breed of inkjet printers called 'photo-printers'. Earlier, a user needed to download images from a digital camera to his PC before taking a printout, a photo-printer connects directly to a digital camera supporting this feature, allowing you to get your prints straight from the camera.

What's more, their light weight and compact size allow complete portability. HP's Photosmart 130 and Canon's CP100 are

two such printers. The availability of specialised photo-printers such as these is all the more relevant because of the current boom in the digital camera industry. Due to falling prices, more and more people are now buying digital cameras instead of normal film-based ones, and a whole range of models are available from various vendors that cater to enthusiasts and professionals both.

Not too long ago, laser printers were expensive, and out of reach for the average SoHo user. Even with its long-term benefits and convenience, price proved to be a stumbling block. However, the past few months have seen significant reduction in the prices of laser printers, bringing a wide range of options that suit the requirements of various kinds of users—from SoHo to large corporates that require networking capabilities, storage and paper management—built into the printer.





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